on the outside. It sometimes feels like the world has ended and against all the odds, the only thing to survive has been Test cricket, stubbornly forcing its way on, batters playing and leaving to deserted landscapes while I huff, puff and force myself to carry on bowling the channels required. Maybe this is what cricket has always felt like to me. If this is the only thing left to do in the world, I will be happy doing it forever, regardless of what is happening on the outside.

We've all grown longer hair and beards and with the endless isolation, nerves are more frayed. I am chasing my 600th wicket for England. I keep saying that it doesn't matter, that it will be the same as any other wicket, but it is not. It is gnawing away at me. I keep reading and hearing that no seamer has ever taken 600 wickets in the history of cricket. Every time I do, a part of me worries that it is jinxed and that I'll forever be frozen on 599, bowling to no one, hair and beard growing longer, sky growing darker, winter intruding into my space. As I do, my emotionless side that I worked on with Bawden vanishes. This is no time for the emotionless.

My teammates are not helping with this. On day four, they keep dropping catches, like they are in on the conspiracy to leave me stuck on 599. They drop four catches in 37 balls, each of them leaving me more and more angry. Finally, the ball is teed up gently to Stuart Broad at mid-on. It is passively in the air for long enough to leave me a moment to sigh inwardly, that the wicket is finally taken, and we can all move on. Broad goes to take it to his side, the easiest catch anyone will take at any level, and it somehow bounces out, cannoning off his side and on to the floor. He picks up the ball out of sheer anger and hurls it at the stumps as they attempt a shell-shocked run. Mohammad Abbas has been caught up in the moment himself and is way out of his ground. It hits middle stump. Not one England player celebrates, all of them instead sheepishly walking towards me and Stuart, like schoolchildren who know how much trouble they are in. When they get to me, Jos Buttler is covering his smile with his wicketkeeper glove, almost giggling in nervous response. I will find it funny one day, but not now.

A day later, the game is petering out into a draw because of the rain. I am bowling, still searching for the wicket. Everyone dutifully goes about their business, knowing their isolation is almost over and the game certainly a dead rubber. Stuart Broad is stationed at mid-on, hands on hips. I ask him